Parent Communication and Its Association to Positive Latino Youth School Outcomes

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Abstract

Previous research has focused on the deficits of Latino youth in school related topics. On the contrary, little research has been recorded on the positive assets that contribute to positive Latino youth school outcomes. Through analysis of the Minnesota Student Survey 2007, relations between parent communication and school outcomes were assessed. The survey included 7,416 MN Latino youth from grades 6, 9 and 12. By performing various crosstabs, chi-square tests and Cramér's Phi, we found significant relations between parent communication and school outcomes

Research Questions:

- Is parent communication related to how students feels about school and their future school plans?
- Is parent communication related to the amount of time students spend on homework and grade achievement?

Methods

Subjects: The population is derived from Minnesota students in grades 6, 9, and 12, including:

- 7,416 Latino Students
- 75% Mexican, Chicano/ Chicana
- 25% other Latino
- 49% males
- 51% females

Design: Correlational cross sectional study

Variables:
Parent Communication → Feelings toward school & Plans for school
Parent Communication → Grades

Procedure:

- Cross Tabs
- Chi-Square Tests
- Cramér's Phi

Overview of Results

Cramér's Phi	Mexican Descent		Other Latino	
	Father	Mother	Father	Mother
Feel Good About School	.093	**.130**	.104	**.133**
School Plans	.080	**.126**	.093	**.121**
Grades				
A	.116	**.129**	**.155**	.140
B	.114	**.122**	.129	.131
C	.044	.071	.093	.107
D	.098	.107	**.172**	.142

Grades and College Plans Results for Mexican Descent

Mexican Descent Students who Get Mostly A's		
	Talk With Mother	Talk With Father
Most of the time	43%	43%
Some of the time	35%	40%
Not very much	28%	35%
Not at All	24%	29%

Mexican Descent Students with College Plans		
	Talk With Mother	Talk with Father
Most of the time	82%	82%
Some of the time	77%	79%
Not very much	71%	76%
Not at All	64%	68%





Discussion

Parent Communication and Feelings about School

- More frequent Parent Communication is positively related to how students feel about school.
- Communication with mothers has a stronger relation to feelings about school than with fathers.
- There is little difference between students of Mexican descent and other Latino students; the results are similar.

Parent Communication and School Plans

- More frequent Parent Communication is positively related to students' school plans, including plans to attend college.
- Communication with mothers has a stronger relation.

Parent Communication and Grades

- More frequent Parent Communication is positively related to obtaining higher grades such as A's and B's. Less communication is associated with more frequent C's or D's.
- For Students of Mexican descent, communication with mothers has a stronger relation to grades. For other Latino students, communication with fathers has a stronger relation.

Future Questions

- Does changing the frequency of communication with parents improve important school-related outcomes for Latino youth? Can we increase parental communication with Latino youth?
- What role does gender play in the communication between child and parents and the effects on school outcomes?
- Is there an association between the age of the child and the amount of communication between parent and child?
- Is there a difference between Latino students who are US citizens and Latino students who are immigrants in communication with parents?

"Knowing others is intelligence; knowing yourself is true wisdom. Mastering others is strength; mastering yourself is true power." –Lao-Tzu

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